11

Tamil Merchants and the Hindu-Buddhist Diaspora in Early Southeast Asia

John Guy

It is generally accepted that the dissemination of Hindu-Buddhist beliefs and ritual practises in first millennium Southeast Asia were largely the result of initiatives of local rulers to recruit Brahman priests and Buddhist monks able to secure their political and personal welfare. Yet it remains equally self-evident that the medium of transmission of both an awareness of Indian culture, and of its agents and propagators, were the merchant vessels which linked the Indian Ocean diaspora. It follows that a study of early traces of Indian merchant activity in the region should provide clues to the early entry of Indic religious systems into the emerging states and kingdoms of Southeast Asia.

The legacy of these early contacts and engagements are indicated by the scattering of Indic script stone stele inscriptions, both royal and mercantile, and by the regional distribution of the earliest Indic religious imagery, imported and locally produced. The vast majority of the inscriptions identify the patron, usually a local ruler who had assumed the trappings of Hindu culture, often including obeisance to Shiva or Vishnu and a Sanskritised honorific title and name-form. Religious imagery is, after the inscriptions, our single most important source of knowledge of the religious allegiances assumed by these rulers and has, through the study of style and iconography, the potential to clarify the regional origins of the propagators from the subcontinent (Figs. 11.1 and 11.2).

One of the earliest examples of a local ruler with clear Hindu religious affiliations is known from the Purnavarman inscription. This rock-cut inscription was located in a river-bed at Ciaruteun, near Bogor, West Java,

FIGURE 11.1
Ivory comb, a probable Indian import from Andhra Pradesh, *c.* third-fourth centuries, excavated at Chansen, Lopburi, Thailand

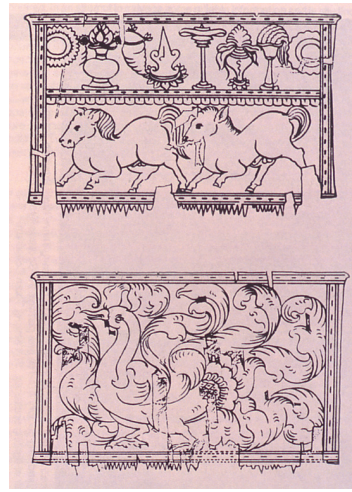


FIGURE 11.2
Gaja-Laksmi, terracotta, probable Indian import, excavated at Chansen, Lopburi, Thailand (Photo: J. Guy 1998)



and dedicated by a local ruler titled Purnavarman, who declared himself as the famous king of Tarumanagara [kingdom] and a devotee of Vishnu, and represented himself by a pair of footprints (*pada*), the same device used to evoke a divine presence (Fig. 11.3).[1] This Sanskrit inscription is written in a cursive Tamil Grantha script in a style associated with the period, *c.* 450. The ruler, presumed to be local, has adopted an Indic name-form, and consistent with most ruler-names appearing in Sanskrit inscriptions of this early period,

FIGURE 11.3
Rock-cut inscription of King Purnavarman, c. 450, *in-situ* Ciaruteun River, near Bogor, West Java (Photo: Indonesian Archaeological Service)



has the south Indian word-ending 'varman', a convention associated with the Pallava-clan of Tamil Nadu.

This rock-cut inscription prominently displays, in the midst of the expressive cursive letters, a *Vishnupada*, the 'sacred footprint' device used in early South Asian religions to evoke a deity's presence. This is the earliest representation of *pada* in Southeast Asia. This inscription and footprint, which is integral to the inscription's meaning, are remarkable for they are the earliest instance of a Southeast Asian ruler invoking not only the authority of an Indic deity, but seemingly personally identifying himself with that god – we are told that the footprints are those of the ruler King Purnavarman, whilst simultaneously being identified as those of Vishnu. Through this inscription Purnavarman asserted his allegiance to, and a close personal identification with, Vishnu, so both evoking and sharing in his divine authority. This is the language of the Puranas, invoked by a new convert to the concept of Indian kingship. Vishnu's *avatar* as the revered ruler Rama, a role model of just kingship, is often represented by footprints, specifically to denote Rama's temporary absence from the throne of Ayutthaya. Such *pada* can therefore have royal as well as divine associations, and this was understandably a popular insignia for royal devotees to employ, intended to invoke the dual meanings. Further, Purnavarman's inscription describes the king as 'capable of destroying his enemies but beneficent to loyal princes'. The threatening tone is in keeping with other early Sanskrit inscriptions from western Indonesia, the so-called 'curse inscriptions', which invoke dark magic against those who display disloyalty to a ruler. The power of these magic spells and invocations has strong tantric overtones. Similar language is employed at the naga-stele inscription from Telaga Batu, Palembang, dated to the late seventh century, where subjects are commanded to 'drink the curse' which would be activated by acts of disloyalty (Fig. 11.4).[2]

The earliest Indic inscriptions in Southeast Asia are almost certainly the seven steles from Kutei, eastern Borneo, attributed on palaeographic grounds to the late fourth century (Fig. 11.5).[3] They were installed by a local ruler

FIGURE 11.4
Telaga Batu stele, seventh century, Palembang, South Sumatra, Nasional Museum, Jakarta

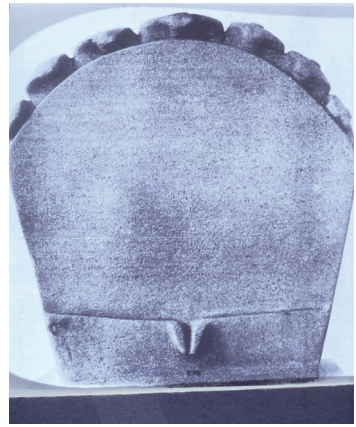


FIGURE 11.5
***Yupa* post installed by King Mulavarman, late fourth century, Kutei, eastern Kalimantan. Nasional Museum, Jakarta**



who titled himself Mulavarman. Highly significantly, they record animal sacrifice and gift-giving rituals performed by Brahmans at a designated site, on behalf of the king. It is remarkable that here we have – from the outset of an Indic written record in Southeast Asia – clear evidence of Brahmanic ritual activities and, by implication, the presence of Indian Brahman priests in a 'court context'. The simultaneous appearance of Sanskrit and Brahmans

was a necessary coincidence. The inscriptions explicitly refer to these steles as *yupa*, sacrificial posts employed in Vedic animal sacrifice, and to the existence of designated sacred space where these rituals were performed; the latter may be presumed to be of a temporary nature, as Vedic ritual dictate, perhaps a temporary placement of fired bricks. According to Brahmanic prescriptions, *yupa* posts should be wooden, and were only rarely rendered in stone as a commemorative record of the enactment of a highly significant ritual sacrifice. In the archaeological records of early northern India up to this period only around four such stone posts are known, two from Kushana Mathura.[4] One of these carries an inscription recording the event it commemorates together with a depiction, carved into the trunk of the post, of the rope used to secure the sacrificial animal. It is curious that the Kutei examples are not post-like, but rather rough-hewn monoliths bearing relatively refined inscriptions in a box-head style Grantha script. How they related to sacrifice in Kutei is unknown.

These epigraphs are the earliest record of a local ruler assuming the trappings of Hindu kingship in insular Southeast Asia. The development of Kutei from a fiefdom to a small 'Indic' kingdom was in all probability linked to contacts with Indian merchants seeking the natural wealth of the region. That the kingdom grew in importance, sustained by the export of Borneo's natural riches, is witnessed by the discovery of a series of Hindu stone sculptures, first reported in 1907 and the more recent discovery of a series of high quality bronze Buddhist images, the latter in a Central Javanese style and therefore attributable to the late first millennium.[5] The latter images could be imports from the metropolitan centre of Java, but another possibility should also be considered, that Kutei, with its abundance of copper and gold, served not only as a source of raw materials for Java's religious institutions, but may have been a production centre.

This hypothesis is supported by two new forms of evidence; first, the reporting by Edwards McKinnon of quantities of discarded bronze images and metal scrap artefacts found in the Kutei region some years ago.[6] This included a Buddhist Bodhisattva image of a type known from Javanese finds.[7] Secondly, recent evidence from two shipwrecked cargoes excavated in the Java Sea, known as the Intan and Cirebon cargoes, supports the notion of multiple production nodes in the 'Sailendra world', centres close to the sources of raw materials.[8] These vessels appear, on the balance of evidence, to have been sailing from Sumatra to Java with international cargoes that included consignments of metal ingots, 'scrap' copper alloy, *and* cast bronze religious images and ritual objects. Kutei could have assumed a similar role in the supply of religious imagery to Java. This raises the possibility that a wealthy metropolitan centre like Java was being supplied from its periphery with not only the raw materials for the manufacture of religious paraphernalia, but also

with actual finished images and ritual objects made in the client's designated style.

Locating Tamils in Southeast Asia

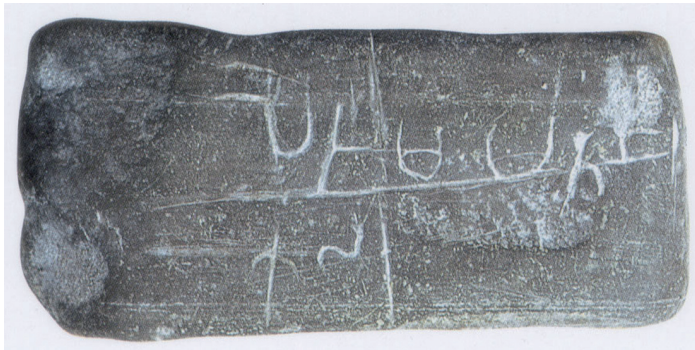
Tamils appear to have been dominant amongst the earliest Indian traders to operate in insular Southeast Asia, supported by successive kingdoms in southern India. This is supported both by the nature of the earliest Indic inscriptions found which, as noted, consistently exhibit south Indian affiliations, and by the distribution of these inscriptions. They chronicle the centres of commercial activity and by implication the trade routes – indeed they are one of the few sources for an understanding of these early trade routes and their commercial nodes. The distribution of these inscriptions thus may be accepted as faithfully mirroring the centres of most intensive mercantile contact.

This model would suggest that the earliest sustained contact between India and Southeast Asia took place at riverine coastal sites, as witnessed by the fourth to seventh centuries inscriptions of Java, Borneo, Sumatra, the Malay peninsula and coastal Vietnam. The religious activity is predominantly Hindu but also, especially in the Srivijayan territories of southern Sumatra, Buddhist.[9] The early inscriptions in Southeast Asia have been consistently located at coastal sites served by riverine systems which allowed access to the commercial riches of the hinterlands whilst linking them to the international exchange system. These locales must have been important to both intra-regional trading and to the long-distance trade which served to link India and China through Southeast Asia.

Inscriptions from a variety of sources make clear that Tamil participation in long distance trade to Southeast Asia and beyond was sustained over most part of the historical period, beginning in the early centuries CE. The goldsmith's touchstone from Wat Klong Thom, Krabi province, peninsular Thailand, is the earliest Tamil inscription; it is written in Tamil Brahmi script of the third or fourth centuries CE (Fig. 11.6). The archaeological work currently being done on the Thai peninsula, at Khao Sam Kheo in Champhun province on east coast and the finds at Takuapa on the west coast, indicate levels of processing and production which went beyond the activities of traders alone.[10] The excavations at Khao Sam Kheo indicate the extent to which early trading settlements undertook the processing of raw materials sourced in the region, such as gold, and the fabrication of imported materials such as glass into artefacts for re-sale.

A number of Sanskrit inscriptions appear in mainland Southeast Asia from the same period, the earliest being the Vo Canh stele, found near the coastal city of Nha Trang, central Vietnam in Cham territory. The Vo Canh

FIGURE 11.6
Goldsmith's touchstone from Wat Klong Thom, Krabi province, peninsular Thailand, with the earliest Tamil inscription in Southeast Asia, third or fourth century. Phra Kru Athon Sangarakit Museum, Khuan Luk Pat, Klong Thom district (Photo courtesy: Tsugisato Omura)



stele, close in date to the Kutei *yupa* steles but written in a cruder Sanskrit, signals the importance of the early trading states that were emerging along the India-China sea route. Three additional inscriptions from My Son, a major religious centre from the early northern Cham kingdoms, are all associated with the oldest recorded Cham ruler, Bhadravarman I, who employed the honorific title 'Dharmamaharaja'. They are attributed to *c.* CE 400, and have been interpreted as referring to sacrifices to Shiva as Bhadesvara.

A little later in date – probably mid-fifth century – is the highly important Devanika inscription at Champasak, located on the Mekong River in southern Laos, the earliest Sanskrit inscription belonging to the Chenla Kingdom and so representing the beginning of the Khmer epigraphic record. Recent investigations of this stele have revealed that it is inscribed on a tripartite pillar of square, octagonal and round section; that is, a *linga*-form stele, the earliest occurrence of an inscribed *linga* in early Southeast Asian epigraphy.[11]

Lands of Gold

Indian merchants were drawn to Southeast Asia by its legendary natural wealth, of spices, resins and other forest products, and by its precious metals, especially gold. They were also attracted to the region because it served as the gateway to trade with China. As the maritime routes were mastered, so trade between southern India and China expanded. Chinese silk was imported at Pompuhar in the early centuries CE, according to the *Shiappadikaram*,[12] probably by Tamil merchants operating via entrepôts in the Malay peninsula. Southeast Asia featured early in Indian literature as an important source of gold, especially in Buddhist Jataka stories. Therein the region is identified by

the title *Suvarnadvipa* (Island of Gold) and *Suvarnabhumi* (Land of Gold). Western Indonesia in particular yielded a steady supply of gravel and river-borne alluvial gold; Sumatra, Kalimantan and the peninsula all played a role in this trade. Evidence of gold working activity in Sumatra and the Malay peninsula in particular confirm that Tamils were active in this process: the goldsmith's touchstone newly deciphered inscription found at one of the earliest identified entrepôts of peninsular Thailand, Wat Khlong Thom, indicates it was the property of a Tamilian identifying himself as 'Perum patan' [the great goldsmith].[13]

The ongoing link between Tamil merchants, gold trade and a religious presence is further underscored by the important discoveries at Takuapa, on the west coast of the Malay peninsula, of an early ninth-century Tamil inscription and three large-scale stone Hindu sculptures in the Pallava style (Fig. 11.7). The sculptures are remarkable for their iconographic and stylistic completeness and for their scale, the principal male figure standing at over 2 m. These monumental icons could only have been completed under Brahmanical direction, though we only speculate as to the ethnicity of the artisans responsible. Given the scale of these sculptures, we may reasonably assume that a temple or shrine existed to house them, though no traces have been recorded of a structure which seems adequate to this purpose. The Takuapa inscription provides some important clues on this question: it is dedicated to the foundation of a new tank, named as *Sri Avani naranam*, which Nilakanta Sastri, who published his revised translation in 1949, links to the reign of the Pallava king Nandivarman III (r. 826-50).[14] The presence of a tank clearly implies the pre-existence of a temple or shrine, as a tank is integral to the ritual life of a Hindu temple, essential for the performance of purification activities. If the temple was also new, it would undoubtedly have been mentioned in the inscription, so we may assume a temple or shrine of some sort predated the tank inscription.

FIGURE 11.7
The Pra Narai Hindu sculptures, mid-ninth century, *in situ*, Takuapa, Thai Peninsula. Photograph mid-twentieth century (after Quaritch Wales, 1976)



The inscription further states that this project was the work of the members of three Indian merchant guilds, two of whose names have been deciphered: the *manigri ramattar* and the *sena mugattar.* The *mani giraman* was one of the most prominent itinerant merchant organisations whose activities are well recorded in Tamil Nadu and Kerala, and inscriptions indicate that they were most active from the ninth to fourteenth centuries.[15] The name *sena mugattar* does not appear in Indian sources but is known in Javanese inscriptions where it refers to employees of a guild, possibly the militia/armed guards (Tamil: *viran kodiyar*) who were employed to protect the guild member's godowns and caravans. Bronze weapons excavated in Sumatra have been identified as south Indian in type, and may be associated with such merchant militia.[16]

A clue as to the activities of the Tamil residents of Takuapa is found in the form of traces of processed gold in the soil, evidence that this location had served as a gold working centre. Taken together with the goldsmith's 'anvil' found at Krabi, we get an emerging picture of the nature of the Indian mercantile presence, extending beyond sourcing of materials to engaging in their processing and refinement. The Takuapa inscription and its implied Hindu activity together with the style of the associated statuary relate this phase of the site to the ninth century. When the gold working sites were active is less clear.

A Tamil settlement in Southeast Asia at a place named 'Takola' is confirmed as early as the third century CE by a Buddhist canonical text, the *Mahanidessa*. This refers to trade with 'Takola', a place of riches in Suvarnadvipa, which may correspond with Takuapa. Irrespective of whether this identification is correct – other sites have a claim to this title – the text confirms the continuity of Tamil commercial activity in the Thai peninsula over most of the first millennium. It is interesting that the earliest reference is in a Buddhist source, but that much of the archaeological evidence, especially from the second half of the millennium, is of Hindu activity. This pattern is mirrored elsewhere, as seen in the Indian settlements in the riverine sites of the Bujang valley, Kedah, on the west coast of the Malayan peninsula.

Another Tamil inscription, belonging to the height of the Chola period – the eleventh century – was recorded from Lobu Tua, Barus, on the west coast of Sumatra. This is a region rich in camphor, benzoin and alluvial gold. It was dedicated in February-March 1088, and records the activities of the famous Indian merchant guild the *ainurruvar*, whose members resident at Barus committed to a charitable fund for the benefit of members and their families ('our sons'). The inscription makes clear that it is enforceable by the withdrawal of trading rights should anyone fail to pay the *anchutuntayam* [proportion of revenue] fee in gold. This right to trade is described as having the privilege to 'step on the spread cloth'.[17] A further three Tamil inscriptions have been reported from Sumatra, one from Aceh, one from Barus and one

from an inland site in Minangkabau province, the latter indicating that Tamil traders both penetrated and settled in the hinterland as well as at coastal centres.

South Indian communities, including communities of Brahmans, settled in peninsular Thailand also left an inscriptional record. A Sanskrit inscription in Grantha script is recorded from Wat Mahaeyong, Nakhon Si Thammarat, and now displayed in the National Museum, Bangkok. George Coedès attributed it to the seventh century and provided a translation which indicates a Buddhist affiliation, invoking all to uphold the Dharma, dissolve desire and passion, and to be impartial to happiness and grief.[18] A rock-cut inscription at Chong Koi, Nakhon Si Thammarat province, identifies the existence of a community of Saivite Brahmans and extols them to both practise the rituals correctly and to live harmoniously with their host community.[19]

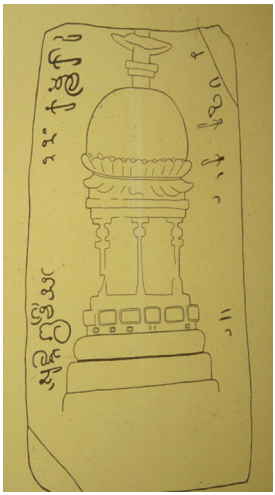
Whilst Brahmanical ritual and its accoutrements came to be associated with kingship and statecraft in early Southeast Asia, the Buddhist presence appears to be more linked to commerce. Monumental stupa buildings were underway in mainland and peninsular Southeast Asia in the early centuries CE; the great stupas at Sri Ksetra and Nakhom Pathom bear witness to this, as do the foundations of other stupas dating to the early centuries CE at Beikthano and other Pyu sites.[20] These great foundations, no doubt understood in their day to house Buddha relics, were commemorated on miniature clay devotional icons and meditation plaques (Fig. 11.8).

Among the earliest Buddhist inscriptions in Southeast Asia are two steles found in the Lembah Bujang valley area of Kedah (Fig. 11.9). Both steles follow the same form: an engraving of a stupa with Buddhist creed in Sanskrit around the border. Epigraphically the south Indian Grantha script is datable to around CE 450-500. The inscription found at Seberang Perai is unique amongst finds of this kind in that it names the donor. He is identified as 'the great sea-captain Buddhagupta', 'a resident of Raktamrittika', possibly a

FIGURE 11.8
Votive tablet depicting a stupa, Pyu, *c.* eighth century, probably Sri Ksetra, Prome, Burma



FIGURE 11.9
Buddhist commemorative stele, *c.* sixth century, Bujang valley, Kedah, Malaysia



Sanskrit form of the Malay place name 'Tanah Merah', meaning 'Red Earth', presumably another entrepôt located in the Malay peninsula.[21] The remaining text is of Buddhist creed and has an appeal that 'He and his fellow travellers by all means … be successful in their voyage'. The stele was found by Col. James Low in the 1840s near the Muda River, in Kedah close to what he described as the ruins of a Buddhist temple. Along this same river valley the remains of a number of Hindu shrines and temples have been excavated and restored, identifying the valley as a major first millennium entrepôt, patronised by Indian merchants, amongst others.[22] Traces of Hindu-Buddhist religious imagery have been recovered, along with late Tang and Five Dynasties Chinese ceramics, and glassware from the Islamic Middle East.

The excavated trade goods in the Bujang valley mirror, in part, the Belitung shipwreck cargo recently discovered in the Java Sea.[23] It is an early ninth century vessel and has been identified as a *dhow* built in the Arab-shipbuilding tradition, built of African hardwoods. Judging from its cargo, it was active in the China-Persian Gulf trade.[24] It is significant that this is the first Arab *dhow* to be identified in Southeast Asian waters.[25] By the time of its sailing, entrepôts in south-east Sumatra had emerged to compete with Kedah, most notably Srivijaya, centred in the Musi River estuary in the vicinity of Palembang.

The Tamil Presence in China

As early as CE 510, a foreign trading mission to the Chinese court identified as Indian, is described in the Tang annals. By the mid-eighth century the

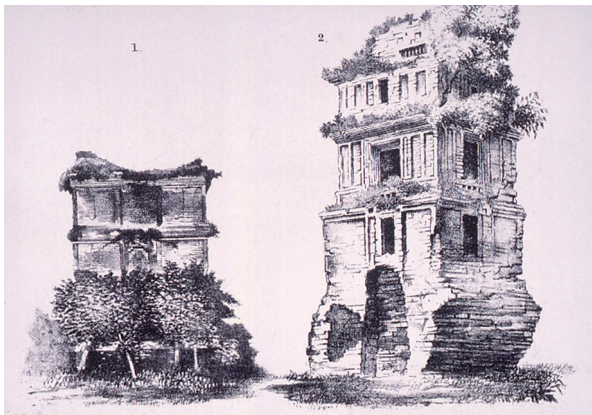
Indian presence in Guangzhou had expanded to the extent that they supported three temples, complete with resident Brahman priests.[26] In CE 750 the Buddhist monk Kanshin recorded that on the river at Guangzhou 'There are merchantmen [ocean-going ships] belonging to the *Bolomen* [Indians], the *Posi* [Persians] and the *Kunlun* [Malays] … of which it is difficult to determine the number.' It continues to explain that there are 'three monasteries of the *Bolomen* [Indians] where Brahmans reside'.[27] These Hindu religious establishments must have existed alongside places of worship for other expatriate communities, notably Buddhist shrines and monasteries, and mosques for the Arab-Persian traders (and for an emerging indigenous Chinese Muslim community).

The pervasive presence of Indian priests and monks in court and temple life in Southeast Asia and, by extension in the expatriate communities in south China, is clear from the archaeological evidence of Hindu temples and sculptures in Quanzhou.[28] According to Zhao Rugua's *Zhufanzhi* (Description of Barbarian Peoples), in the Yongxi period (984-88) of the Northern Song a Buddhist monk from India (Tianzhu) purchased land in the southern suburbs of Quanzhou for the purpose of building a Buddhist shrine. This structure still existed at the time that Zhao Rugua was writing in the early thirteenth century.[29] Funds were presumably provided by both the Indian merchant community and Chinese Buddhists, but the Song administration also provided tracts of land for the use of foreign communities, to create the 'foreign quarters' (*fanfang*). These communities acquired a degree of legal autonomy, with the post of *Shahbandar* (Persian: harbourmaster) to act as the legal intermediary between the foreign communities and the Chinese authorities.

The beginning of the eleventh century saw the expansion of the Cholamandala through a combination of military conquest and commercial acumen. The commercial importance of long distance trade to the Cholas was acknowledged in the reign of Rajendrachola (1012-44), with the sending in 1015 of the first diplomatic mission of the Chola period to China. These missions continued on an irregular basis until the close of the thirteenth century. The Chinese presence in Tamil Nadu was acknowledged by the royal endowment of a Buddhist temple at Nagapattinam. A place of Chinese worship appears to have existed there since the reign of the Pallava king Narasimhavarman II, but the structure known as the 'Chinese Pagoda' was probably constructed under Chola patronage in the early thirteenth century (Fig. 11.10). According to the fourteenth-century writer on Chinese overseas trade Wang Dayuan, it was built in 1267 to encourage the visits of Chinese merchants.

The Chola missions were effectively in competition with those from Srivijaya, in all likelihood the principal reason for the punishing raids sent

FIGURE 11.10
'Chinese pagoda' of Nagapattinam, possibly built in 1276.
Drawing after W. Elliot, *The Indian Antiquary*, 1878



by the Cholas in 1026 and 1068. The 'kingdom of Sanfoqi' (Srivijaya) is recorded in the famous Canton inscription of 1079 as funding the renovation and maintenance of several Buddhist temples in that port-city.[30] Srivijaya may be assumed to have still been under a degree of Chola suzerainty at this time, and if this was the case, then this inscription may be interpreted as an attempt by merchant delegations under Chola control to enhance the standing of their expatriate community in Guangzhou. The presence of south Indian merchants belonging to the Chola-mandala was in turn actively encouraged by the Song administration

Archaeological evidence exists of Chola-period south Indian trading community settlements at intermediate locations in the Thai-Malay peninsula. The scale of the ongoing role of Tamil merchants in this period is confirmed by several important discoveries. A dated Tamil inscription preserved in the Buddhist temple of Wat Boroma That, Nakhon Si Thammarat, and first translated and published by Noboru Karashima records the donation (*brahmadeya*) by a named individual, Danma Senapati, probably a merchant, of funds to endow a Hindu temple and/or community of *brahmanas* in three shares.[31] Importantly, a site north of Nakhon Si Thammarat has yielded architectural elements from a substantial Hindu temple in the late Chola style (Fig. 11.11). Architectural fragments, including a capital with inverted pendant lotus bud designs, are now displayed in the National Museum at Nakhon Si Thammarat. First reported by Quaritch Wales in the 1930s, this site has not, to my knowledge, been fully investigated. Possible associations between the Wat Boroma That inscription and these architectural fragments warrants close examination and in all probability share a common ancestry. The inscription is cyclically dated, most probably to 1258 or 1265.

FIGURE 11.11
Pillar capital, late Chola style, from Nakhon Si Thammarat, National Museum, Nakhon Si Thammarat (Photo: after Quaritch Wales, 1976)



The second site to yield evidence of Chola-period temples in Southeast Asia is the Lembah Bujang, the riverine valley site in Kedah described earlier, which has a continuous archaeological record of international entrepôt trade from at least the sixth century. The recovery of a Chola-period balustrade incorporating a lion design makes clear that south Indian merchant community activity continued in the valley well into the Chola period (Fig. 11.12).

Quanzhou

The most spectacular indicator of Tamil merchant activity outside India in the Chola period is the remains of Hindu temple, or temples, at the southern Chinese port-city of Quanzhou, Fujian, which I have discussed at length elsewhere.[32] Like the contemporary sites in Southeast Asia, the Hindu temple(s) at Quanzhou had all but disappeared from the city landscape by

FIGURE 11.12
Balustrade section, late Chola period, from Lembah Bujang, Kedah. Site Museum, Lembah Bujang (Photo: J. Guy, 2001)



the Ming period. This became clear from 1940 when the city wall – a Ming construction – was demolished during the Sino-Japanese war, and a large quantity of 'Hindu relics' and other foreign religious stone artefacts, were recovered from the core of the wall, where these cut granite stones had been used as filler.[33]

The Tamil identity of a Hindu temple is confirmed by an inscription also discovered in association with these architectural remains (Fig. 11.13). It consists of five lines of Tamil and a final line in Chinese. It is dated to April (month of Chittirai) in the Saka era 1203, equivalent to CE 1281. The dedication is to Shiva (Hara), and the donor identifies himself as Sambandh Perumal, but also uses an honorific name 'Tava-chchakka-tavar-ttigal', perhaps a devotee of the Saiva saint [Sambandar], which suggests he may be a native of Kumbakonam, in the Tanjavur district of Tamil Nadu. Other fragments of Hindu architecture have been found integrated into the fabric of domestic dwellings in the southern district of Quanzhou, particularly in the vicinity of the Tonghuai city-gate where we may therefore assume the temple was located. The site itself has disappeared beneath urban expansion.

The most complete series of architectural elements to be preserved *in situ* was two pillars and a series of basement reliefs integrated in a Ming-period renovation of the Kaiyuan temple (Fig. 11.14). This is a remarkable instance of cultural syncretism, in which alien architectural elements – late Chola style pillars decorated with cartouche panels depicting scenes from Hindu mythology and basement stones with lotus petal mouldings and decorated with lions – are integrated into the fabric of a Chinese Ming-style Buddhist temple. Turning briefly to the subject matter of the Hindu reliefs, they concern themselves with themes associated both with Shiva and Vishnu. Those scenes depicted on the pillars are exclusively devoted to Vishnu, both as supreme Lord enthroned with his consorts Sri Devi and Bhu Devi, and in some of his more popular avatars (manifestations/appearances), notably as Narasimha, as the infant and youthful Krishna, and Krishna subduing the *naga* Kaliya.

FIGURE 11.13
Tamil inscription, from an untraced Hindu temple, Quanzhou, dated 1281. Xiamen University Museum of Anthropology, Xiamen



FIGURE 11.14
Kaiyuan temple, Ming-period renovation, incorporating Hindu pillars from a lost thirteenth-century temple, Quanzhou (Photo: J. Guy, 1984)



Only one medallion depicts Shiva, as the wandering mendicant. In addition, one freestanding sculptural image of Vishnu survives, an unfinished image over 1 m in height.

The relatively lifeless rendering of these most dynamic and gracious subjects makes clear the nature of manufacture at the Hindu temple. It is obvious that the sculptures are not the work of Indian artisans, but of stonemasons trained in the Chinese tradition. Such is the complexity of Indian temple building that it must be assumed that an Indian architect versed in the *sastric* traditions was responsible for directing their construction. Such a skilled *sthapati* must have been recruited by the Tamil merchant community, in all likelihood from within their own community in south India.

The iconographic content of the Hindu reliefs of Quanzhou are of especial interest because they depict localized versions of Hindu myths, and legends associated with known saints of south India (Fig. 11.15). In my 2001 paper I examined the extent to which localising the origins of the scenes depicted could throw light on the regional affiliations of the Tamil merchant active in Quanzhou, and hence enable us to suggest the guild organisations to which they may well have been aligned.[34] The localising of these subjects to sites in proximity of the Kaveri River in Tamil Nadu provided some tentative indications as to the origins of the merchants and their priests who

FIGURE 11.15
Elephant worshipping a *linga* with flowers; relief from an untraced Hindu temple, Quanzhou, thirteenth century. Maritime Museum, Quanzhou



commissioned and directed the construction of the temples in southern China.

The Quanzhou Hindu temple remains are not an isolated phenomenon, but rather a final and spectacular manifestation of a long process of dissemination of a Tamil presence along the maritime trade route that stretched from the ports of the Coromandel and Malabar coasts, to Southeast Asia and ultimately to those of southern China.

NOTES

1. Vogel, 1925.
2. See J. de Casparis, 1956 and Kulke, 1993 for a discussion of the inscriptions meaning, and J. Guy, 2004a for the acculturation of Indian naga-imagery in early Southeast Asia.
3. First published by Vogel, 1918, and further finds by Chabbra, 1949.
4. Two are on display in the Government Museum, Mathura, Uttar Pradesh.
5. Nieuwenhuis, 1907, vol. II: 115, Pl. X, cited in Bosch, 1926. The bronzes appeared on the art market in the 1990s.
6. McKinnon, 2000, and verbal communication.
7. Guy, 2005: Fig. 8.
8. Guy, 2004b.
9. McKinnon, 1985-86, provides a valuable overview of the distribution of inscription and images for southern Sumatra.
10. See Glover and Bellina, and Boonyarit Chaisuwan, in this volume.
11. Coedès, 1954.This author was instrumental in having the *linga* 'excavated' from the garden of the late Prince of Champasak's residence in 2005, revealing its tripartite form; it is now displayed in the Champasak site museum. Inscribed *lingas* are very rare in India, but occur more frequently in Southeast Asia, especially in Java.
12. Wolters, 1967: 82-83.
13. Shanmugan, 1996: 101.
14. Sastri, 1949.
15. Abrahams, 1988.
16. Personal communication, E. Edwards McKinnon.
17. Subbarayalu, 2002.
18. Coedès, 1961: 32-33.

19. Ibid.: 38-40.
20. Aung Thaw, 1968.
21. 'Red Earth' is also the meaning of the name by which the Chinese knew a small entrepôt at this time on the east coast of the Malay Peninsula, *Chi tu*. It is referred to in the seventh-century *Sui shu*, see Guy, 2004a.
22. Rahman and Yatim, 1990.
23. Guy, 2003.
24. Guy, 2006
25. Flecker, 2000.
26. Sastri, 1937.
27. This and the other Chinese sources that follow are discussed in Guy, 2001.
28. Guy, 1994.
29. Hirth and Rockhill, 1911.
30. Lo, 1967. See also H. Kulke, K. Kesavapany and V. Sakhuja (eds.), *Nagapattinam to Suvarnadwipa: Reflections on the Chola Expeditions to Southeast Asia*, Singapore, ISEAS, 2009.
31. Dated either 1183 or 1283; see Karashima, 2002: 13.
32. Guy, 1994, 2001, 2010.
33. Published by Wu, 1956.
34. Guy, 2001: 296-302.

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